Looking at narratives

Tzvetan Todorov devised a way of analysing narratives according to the way they move forward through different stages. He suggested that many narratives, regardless of their genre, could be broken into specific stages for analysis.

Todorov's Narrative Stages

Equilibrium – the setting is established, key character(s) are introduced and the storyline is set up.

Disruption – oppositional character(s) appear and the story takes a particular direction.

Recognition of disruption – the lives of characters and events are interwoven. Tension builds throughout this section, which is often the longest.

Attempt to repair disruption – the highest point of tension after which there is a change in dynamic.

Reinstatement of equilibrium – matters are sorted out, problems are solved and questions answered.

Emily was sick of waiting around for a wimpy prince to come and ask for her hand in marriage, so she decided to find one for herself. She soon came upon a dragon who was singeing the top of a freckle-faced boy's head.

Being a resourceful princess, Emily set a trap for the dragon and then tricked him into following her.

'You're just a silly girl, and even though it's hardly worth it, I'm going to toast you to a crisp and have you for pudding!' boomed the dragon. Just then, the branches he was standing on gave way, and he fell down a very deep well, his fire put out once and for all.

Emily returned to the boy. 'What's your name?' she asked.

'Prince Matthew,' said the boy.

'That'll do nicely,' said Emily. 'Where do you live?'

'In Happy-Ever-After,' he replied.

'That'll do nicely too,' said Emily. And with that, she and Matthew rode off together to Happy-Ever-After.



5 Emily and the dragon

Why, you may well be asking, is the children's fairy story in **5** in a book on GCSE Media Studies? The answer is that the **narrative structure** suggested by Todorov fits this story so perfectly, and there are many useful activities arising from it.

ACTIVITY 11

1 Create your own chart to show how the theory can be applied to Emily's story. The first two sections have been done to help you.

Equilibrium:	*We meet key character Emily, find out that she wants to find a prince for herself.*
Disruption:	*Emily meets oppositional characters: the dragon and boy.*
Recognition of disruption:	
Attempt to repair:	
Reinstatement:	

2 Work in a small group to find each of the stages in two films you know well.

3 Watch a short narrative – a cartoon would be a good text to use. Analyse its narrative structure by breaking it down into its five stages.

4 Think of your own simple story featuring a small boy or girl. Write a 50-word story that follows this narrative structure and read it to a partner.

Playing with narratives

Obviously not all narratives fit into the linear progression suggested by Todorov, especially if they are trying to do something different or unpredictable. For example, in the film *Back To The Future* (1985) directed by Steven Spielberg, a boy travels back in time to meet the scientist who invented time travel. The stages of the narrative in this film are not in chronological order. Can you think of any other examples?

The correct term for something that does not fit a recognised theory is a **subversion.** You may recognise these subversion techniques:

- *Flashback* – where a section of the film is referred back to, e.g. *The Hulk* (2003) directed by Ang Lee.
- *Flashforward* – where a section of the film from the future is shown before it would normally have happened, e.g. *The Matrix Reloaded* (2003) directed by the Wachowski brothers.
- *Twist* – where part of the film (often the end) is unpredictable or even shocking, e.g. *The Sixth Sense* (1999) directed by M. Night Shyamalan.
- *Parallel narratives* – where the lives of characters move alongside each other for some of the film without them meeting, e.g. *Independence Day* (1996) directed by Roland Emmerich.

KEY TERMS

Narrative structure the way in which a story is organised and shaped in terms of time and events

Oppositional characters characters who will play opposite the key central character, either in a relationship, e.g. the hero/heroine, or in conflict, e.g. the hero/villain

Subversion when a technique is used which does not fit a theory or the usual way of doing something

ACTIVITY 12

Divide into groups. Look again at Emily's story in **5**. Each group should prepare to re-tell the story, using one or more subversions. Change the original version so that the narrative no longer follows the same path. The following suggestions may help you:

- Flashback – start the story from the moment when Emily is facing the dragon.
- Flashforward – begin the story with a dream sequence in which Emily faces a fire-breathing beast.
- Twist – Emily does not have to be human!
- Parallel narratives – tell Emily's story side by side with Prince Matthew's (or the dragon's) story. This could make the audience feel differently towards them.

Audience positioning

Audiences enjoy texts most when they are really involved in them. When you analyse a media text such as a film, identify the key techniques that 'sew' the audience into it. When they are genuinely hooked into the text's narrative and development, it is as if they actually have their own position in it. You can see why this is so important – someone who is really involved in a text is much less likely to switch it off or put it back on the shelf. Here are some techniques that help an audience to become involved or positioned in a film or television text.

- **Point-of-view shots** – the camera adopts the position of a character within the text. This can be an over-the-shoulder shot, looking at whatever the character is looking at, or a shot from the point of view of the character. This is particularly powerful when the character is experiencing a strong emotion – the viewer is more likely to feel their emotion when taking their point of view.
- **Reaction shots** – the camera moves to an extreme close-up of a character's face to show their reaction to something that has happened (see **6**: Eddie Murphy in *The Nutty Professor* (1996)).



6 Reading facial expression is crucial to understanding a character's reaction